Was I actually doing something that was against the national interest? If so, should I continue serving the vested interests of some persons, even at the cost of the larger interests of the nation? If not, how should I tell Gary to take me off such assignments in future? Would he mind, and what would be the consequences of that? By the time my plane landed in New Delhi I had made up my mind – irrespective of the consequences, I would tell Gary that I would no longer like to be associated with any work or operation related to the ongoing developments in Punjab and request him to relieve me of the charge of the two top secret and sensitive divisions to avoid meeting him almost daily, sometimes more than once.

I called on Gary the first thing next morning to apprise him of my activities during the visit. As soon as I entered his room, he stood up, shook hands with me and congratulated me for a job well done. 'Now get ready to move to Bangkok, as head of the R&AW station there,' he told me. I thanked Gary for his appreciation but politely said, 'Sir, I am not going anywhere. I think something terrible is going to happen before the end of next year and I would like to be in India at that time.'

'Sir,' I continued, 'I don't want to be associated with anything which serves the interest of one person, one party or one family, which has the potential of shaking the foundations of the country. In view of that, please relieve me from my present posts and commitment to special assignments and post me to an analysis division.'

Gary was surprised, if not shocked, at this completely unexpected response to his words of appreciation. In the normal course, no one sought to be transferred from high-profile and sought-after divisions to a nondescript analysis division, and neither to decline an attractive posting to head the most important station of the R&AW in south east-Asia. Also, no one in his normal frame of mind was supposed to blame the policies followed by the prime minister, and that too one of Indira Gandhi's stature, as reasons thereof.

Gary sensed that what I had just told him was not simply an emotional outburst but was based on my knowledge of certain facts, which he wanted to avoid discussing further. I was, however,